
Brutal Isms

Revised Long-Form Proposal

Artistic Statement

I know exactly why I make art. I am finally making it for that reason.

For over a decade I have produced at the highest level of the beauty and fashion industries, directing, building, designing, and performing work at a professional standard that few can sustain across so many disciplines at once. I have done it brilliantly. I have also done it at significant cost: filtering instinct through what the client needed, what the brand allowed, what the industry could absorb. I made work that worked for everyone. This project ends that arrangement.

Brutal Isms establishes an independent studio, equipped for sculpture, film, performance, and documentation, as the site of a deliberate return to first principles. The studio is not a backdrop. It is the declaration. A queer Black artist working at full power, building a space that answers to no one, and making work from that position.

This is not a project born from desperation. It is born from arrival.

The return is the protest. The studio is the site. The work is the proof.

Project Description

Seven months. One space. Four disciplines in active relation. No permission.

Brutal Isms is a seven-month studio project structured around daily research through making. I will use one independent studio as a laboratory to test how sculpture, film, movement, and documentation behave under pressure: where they sharpen one another, where they resist one another, and where they collapse into a single language. I have practised each of these disciplines professionally for years. I have never held them inside one sustained, self-directed system this rigorously or this fully on my own terms.

The method is cyclical. I build. I test. I film. I move. I document. I review. I rebuild.

That cycle is the research. Sculpture generates weight, obstruction, surface, and spatial resistance. Film tests those forms through scale, light, framing, and sequence. Movement activates the built environment and reveals what the body can carry, refuse, and transform inside it. Documentation tracks decisions, failures, recurrences, and breakthroughs so the next phase of making is more exact than the last. Nothing here is secondary. Nothing sits alone. Creation is not the outcome of the research. Creation is the research method.

Sculpture and Mixed-Media Construction

Concrete, wood, iron hardware, chains, mesh, chain-link fencing, nails, hair, linen, canvas, Vantablack. These materials carry history. Iron is an instrument of confinement. Hair is a site of racial commodification. I reclaim both as building materials. Concrete acts as body. Fabric becomes skin. Metal becomes bone.

The forms will be rough, imperfect, and unearthed. They will reject the polished visual language of the industries I have spent years serving. Some will function as sculpture. Some as furniture. Some as structures

that do not yet belong to a fixed category. All will be tested through proximity, filming, performance, repetition, and physical use. I am not producing static objects. I am building environments that can be inhabited, confronted, and transformed.

Fashion and Art Film

I will write, direct, perform, and edit short films inside the studio, among the objects I have built, under conditions I control. Not content. Cinematic statements.

These films are not adjacent to the sculptural work. They are a method of inquiry inside it. The camera becomes a tool for testing atmosphere, gesture, surface, rhythm, and psychic charge. What sculpture holds in stillness, film pushes into sequence. What performance exposes in real time, film fixes, fractures, and reorders. Shot on a Laowa FX 38, GoPros, and iPhone rigs, the work will use tools already embedded in my professional practice and redirect them toward fully authored, non-commercial image-making.

Movement and Performance

The studio gives me the privacy required to develop movement-based work with precision. The body is not illustration in this project. It is method. It is archive. It is witness.

Movement research will unfold in direct response to the forms, materials, and emotional conditions generated in the space. I will use repetition, improvisation, and filmed study to identify a physical vocabulary that cannot emerge through design or language alone. Some truths arrive only through the body. I know that. This project is built to let them arrive.

Documentation as Practice

Documentation is not secondary to this project. It is one of its engines.

Video, journalling, archival capture, process notes, and image studies will form a parallel body of work that records the evolution of the practice in real time. This record will let me analyse my own methods month by month: what materials recur, what formal tensions persist, what gestures return, what conditions unlock the strongest work. The documentation serves the research first. It belongs to me first. What I choose to share publicly will be selected from a position of authorship, not exposure.

Artistic and Cultural Context

The materials of this project have been used against people like me. That is exactly why I am using them.

I am a queer Black multidisciplinary artist. I am also an artist whose labour has been extracted, aestheticized, and made useful to industries that neither reflect my experience nor share my values. These are not separate facts. They are the condition this work confronts.

Brutal Isms enters a lineage that includes Kara Walker, El Anatsui, and Nick Cave: artists who take loaded materials, inherited violence, and historical residue and transform them into work with formal and political force. What distinguishes this project is its grounding in live, embodied, self-directed studio research. Sculpture, film, performance, and documentation will not be developed as parallel outputs. They will be pursued simultaneously, daily, inside one purpose-built environment, until they produce a single artistic language.

In 2025, I spent six months as the only Black employee at a salon where I was subjected to psychological harassment, unpaid labour, and deliberate racial targeting. I reported the employer to labour standards. I won. The legal victory was real. It did not alter the deeper condition: exploitation of artists and workers at the intersection of multiple marginalised identities is normalized, and refusal still carries a cost.

This project is not a reaction staged for sympathy. It is a refusal to let that experience define the terms of my creative life.

Stone, chains, fencing, iron: tools of confinement, reclaimed as tools of construction. That is not metaphor. That is the practice.

Artistic Risk and Research Questions

The risk here is not ambition. I have lived inside ambition for years. The risk is full authorship.

For an artist whose career has been built on briefs, deliverables, and the management of other people's vision, the most radical act is to build a system accountable only to artistic truth. Brutal Isms takes that risk deliberately. It replaces external permission with method, repetition, reflection, and sustained experimentation.

The questions driving the work are: What does my practice become when it answers only to artistic truth? How do materials marked by oppression transform in the hands of those they were used against? What happens when sculpture, film, movement, and documentation are pursued as one continuous method rather than as separate outputs? What is the relationship between documentation and creation when both happen simultaneously, privately, and without an audience in mind? What becomes possible when an artist with professional-level skills across every discipline stops making work for everyone else?

These questions will not be solved in theory. I will work them through in the studio, daily, across seven months, using a repeatable cycle of making, testing, filming, moving, documenting, and reflecting. The project's rigor lives in that repetition.

Professional Background

Area	Highlights
Creative Direction	Lead creative for Redken Fusion closing shows at Canada's largest hair event; ongoing visual and audio d
Fabrication and Build	Full concept and construction of more than five years of window installations for Priape; independent const
Sculpture	Award-winning practice since high school; sustained work in mixed media, found object, and hand-built for
Film and Performance	Choreography and music direction for live stage productions; directing, producing, and performing visual c
Exhibition	Established relationship with WIP Gallery, Montreal; confirmed venue for the December 2025 exhibition; pr

Timeline

Period	Activity
May 12	Studio scouting
May 20-25	Move-in, setup, materials and equipment sourcing
May 26 - June 26	Month 1 of daily studio research across sculpture, film, performance, and documentation
June 26	Structured check-in: footage review, journaling, planning
July - October	Four creation cycles: 25 days of studio work followed by reflection, sourcing, and rest
November 1	Exhibition announcement
November 20	Exhibition announcement 2, paid Instagram promotion
Nov 27 - Dec 3	Gallery installation and studio takedown
December 4	Opening night
December 4-18	Exhibition residency
December 18	Closing night
December 26-27	Final documentation, report, and project close

Budget Overview

Category	Estimated Cost
Studio rental - 7 months	\$11,200
Camera equipment - Laowa FX 38, GoPros, accessories	\$3,800
Sculpture and fabrication materials	\$11,100
Tools - table saw, sculpting tools, mixing equipment	\$3,050
Exhibition - transport, installation, promotion	\$2,900
Artist fee	\$29,800
Contingency	\$3,150
Total Requested	\$65,000

Full itemized budget to be completed prior to submission.

Dissemination and Community Impact

The work will be shown. The process will be translated. The studio will outlast the grant.

The completed body of work will be exhibited at WIP Gallery, Montreal, opening December 4, 2025. Curated process documentation will be shared with an existing audience of approximately 5,000, not as content, but as evidence of method: what it looks like when a queer Black multidisciplinary artist builds independent infrastructure and works at full autonomy for seven months without commercial mediation.

The private nature of the studio period is not a withdrawal from community. It is the condition that makes a truthful public intervention possible. The exhibition, documentation, and resulting archive will demonstrate a model of practice still too rarely resourced in Canada: one in which a queer Black artist does not fragment himself to fit disciplinary categories, market expectations, or institutional comfort.

For queer Black artists, the impact is concrete. Brutal Isms offers proof that autonomy is not abstraction. It can be built. It can be structured. It can produce serious work without softening itself for legibility.

For the broader commercial creative industries I inhabit, beauty, fashion, film, and music, the intervention is equally direct. These industries routinely mine the aesthetics, labour, and inventiveness of Black queer artists while withholding authorship, ownership, and time. Brutal Isms reverses that flow and restores the artist to his proper position: not stylist, fixer, or visual resource, but origin.

The studio infrastructure established through this project is designed to remain operational and self-sustaining beyond the grant period. This is not a single output. It is the construction of a long-term engine for making work on my own terms.

Art has always been what got me here. This project builds what comes next.